



FREE GUIDE · FOR DENTAL PRACTICES

The Dental Practice's Guide to Compliant Waste Disposal.

A plain-English reference to every regulated waste stream
your practice generates — and how to handle each one right.

DEA-REGISTERED

EPA-COMPLIANT

NO CONTRACT

CERTIFICATE OF DESTRUCTION

Compliance, made simple.

Why dental waste trips practices up.

A dental practice generates at least six distinct regulated waste streams — sharps, amalgam, pharmaceuticals, controlled substances, red-bag biohazard, and the occasional hazardous or special waste. Each is governed by a different agency, and the rules for one do not apply to the next. This guide walks through every stream in plain English: what belongs in it, what does not, the rule behind it, and the simplest compliant way to dispose of it.

The good news

One vendor can take almost all of it — by prepaid mail-back kit, with a Certificate of Destruction on every order and no contract. (Amalgam is the one exception: it is recycled, not incinerated — we help you set that up too.)

AT A GLANCE

Who regulates what.

Agency	What it covers in your practice
OSHA	Bloodborne Pathogens Standard — sharps handling, containers, and annual staff training.
EPA	Dental Amalgam Rule & RCRA — amalgam separators/recycling and hazardous pharmaceutical waste.
DEA	Controlled substances — non-retrievable destruction and DEA Form 41 documentation.
DOT	Safe shipping of regulated medical and pharmaceutical waste in transit.
State	Dental board and environmental rules that vary by state.

THE SIX STREAMS

Every stream, in depth.

Below is each regulated stream your practice produces — what belongs in it, what does not, the rule behind it, how to dispose of it, and a tip to stay clean.

WASTE STREAM 01

Sharps

Anything that can puncture skin. Sharps are your highest-frequency regulated stream and the one OSHA scrutinizes most.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Needles & anesthetic carpules
- Scalpel blades & suture needles
- Orthodontic wire and bands
- Endodontic files & reamers
- Burs & broken instruments

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Bloody gauze or cotton (biohazard)
- Amalgam or capsules (recycling)
- Expired meds (pharmaceutical)
- Extracted teeth (biohazard)

THE RULE · OSHA Bloodborne Pathogens Standard — FDA-cleared, puncture-resistant containers, no overfilling, annual staff training.

DISPOSE WITH · Sharps mail-back kit.

Tip

Replace containers at the fill line (about three-quarters full). Keep them upright, closable, and out of patient reach.

WASTE STREAM 02

Dental amalgam & mercury

Amalgam is roughly 50% mercury, so it is handled unlike any other stream — it is recycled, never incinerated or put down the drain. This is the stream practices most often get wrong.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Amalgam separator solids
- Contact & non-contact scrap
- Spent amalgam capsules
- Chairsides & vacuum trap contents
- Extracted teeth with amalgam

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Red-bag / biohazard waste
- Sharps containers
- Regular trash
- The drain or sewer (prohibited)

THE RULE · EPA Dental Amalgam Rule — an ISO 11143-compliant separator and recycling of captured amalgam; sewer discharge is prohibited.

DISPOSE WITH · An amalgam recycler — mercury is reclaimed, not burned. We can set this up alongside your other streams.

Tip

Store amalgam per your recycler's instructions (often dry, sealed). Never rinse amalgam sludge into a sink.

WASTE STREAM 03

Pharmaceutical waste

Expired and unused non-controlled, non-hazardous medications. Flushing or trashing them is out — they are destroyed and documented.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired anesthetics (lidocaine, articaine)
- Antibiotics (amoxicillin, clindamycin)
- Topical & systemic fluoride
- Non-controlled analgesics
- Manufacturer samples

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Controlled substances (own kit)
- RCRA-hazardous drugs (own kit)
- Carpules with needles attached

THE RULE · Do not drain-dispose; segregate hazardous drugs; destroy with documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Pharmaceutical waste mail-back kit.

Tip

A few drugs are federally hazardous (Stream 06) — keep those separate from routine pharmaceutical waste.

WASTE STREAM 04

Controlled substances

Any Schedule II–V drug your practice stocks for sedation or prescribes. Expired, unused, and wasted controls must be rendered non-retrievable with a documented trail.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Expired / unused Schedule II–V drugs
- Partial or wasted sedation doses
- Surrendered controlled stock

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Non-controlled meds (pharmaceutical kit)
- Sharps
- Nitrous oxide (a gas — see tip)

THE RULE · DEA — render non-retrievable, complete a DEA Form 41 for surrendered controls, and keep witnessed waste logs.

DISPOSE WITH · Controlled-substance / medication mail-back kit, handled to DEA standards.

Tip

Nitrous oxide (N₂O) is a compressed gas, not a controlled substance — it is managed through your gas supplier, not a mail-back kit.

WASTE STREAM 05

Biohazard / regulated medical waste

Items soiled with blood or other potentially infectious material — the classic red-bag stream. Over-bagging everyday trash here is a common, costly habit.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- Blood-soaked gauze & cotton rolls
- Visibly contaminated PPE
- Extracted teeth without amalgam
- Items caked with blood or tissue

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Sharps (sharps kit)
- Lightly soiled everyday gloves
- Amalgam or teeth with amalgam

THE RULE · OSHA plus your state's medical-waste rules — red bags, proper labeling, treatment/destruction, and retained documentation.

DISPOSE WITH · Biohazard mail-back kit.

Tip

Not every glove is red-bag waste — only items visibly contaminated with blood/OPIM. Over-classifying wastes money; check your state's definition.

WASTE STREAM 06

Hazardous & special waste

A few dental items fall outside the routine streams and need their own path. Knowing them prevents both violations and over-paying.

GOES IN THIS STREAM

- RCRA-hazardous drugs (certain formulations)
- Silver-bearing x-ray fixer (film-based)
- Lead foil & old lead aprons
- Some disinfectants / chemicals

DOES NOT GO HERE

- Routine non-hazardous meds
- Digital-radiography waste (there is none)
- General office trash

THE RULE · EPA RCRA for hazardous drugs and chemicals; silver and lead are separately regulated for recycling/recovery.

DISPOSE WITH · RCRA-hazardous mail-back kit for hazardous drugs; silver recovery and lead recycling for imaging waste. We'll help you sort it.

Tip

Going digital for x-rays eliminates fixer and lead-foil waste entirely — one fewer stream to manage.

YOUR CHECKLIST

The dental compliance checklist.

- ☐ Sharps in FDA-cleared containers at chairside, replaced at the fill line.
- ☐ Amalgam separator installed and maintained; amalgam and teeth-with-amalgam recycled — never in red bags or trash.
- ☐ Non-controlled meds and anesthetics segregated and destroyed with documentation.
- ☐ Controlled substances rendered non-retrievable, with DEA Form 41 on file.
- ☐ RCRA-hazardous drugs, x-ray fixer, and lead foil routed to the right program.
- ☐ Staff trained annually on OSHA bloodborne pathogens, documented.
- ☐ Certificates of Destruction retained per your state's rules.

QUESTIONS DENTISTS ASK

Your dental questions, answered.

Can extracted teeth go in the regular trash?

No. Teeth with amalgam are EPA-regulated and recycled with amalgam waste. Teeth without amalgam are potentially infectious and belong in biohazard / red-bag waste — never the regular trash.

Do we really need an amalgam separator?

Yes. Under the EPA Dental Amalgam Rule, practices that place or remove amalgam generally must run an ISO 11143-compliant separator and recycle the captured amalgam.

How do we dispose of expired local anesthetic or epinephrine?

As pharmaceutical waste — in a pharmaceutical-waste kit, destroyed with documentation. Don't flush it or throw it in the trash.

What about controlled substances we keep for sedation?

Schedule II–V drugs must be rendered non-retrievable by a DEA-compliant method, with a DEA Form 41. Our controlled-substance / medication mail-back kit handles this end to end.

How often should sharps containers be replaced?

At the fill line — about three-quarters full. Never overfill; keep them upright, closable, and out of patient reach.

Do we need a contract or a minimum?

No. Kits are buy-as-you-need. You can also set up auto-ship to save 20% and cancel anytime — no contract, no minimums.

What proof do we get for an inspection?

A Certificate of Destruction on every order — audit-ready for OSHA, EPA, DEA, and your state dental board.

THE EASY WAY**Handle it with mail-back.**

Easy Rx Cycle ships prepaid mail-back kits sized to a dental practice — you fill them, seal them, and drop them in the mail. We destroy the contents at our DEA-registered facility and send back a Certificate of Destruction. No pickups, no route fees, no contract.

QUICK REFERENCE · WHICH KIT FOR WHICH STREAM

Waste stream	The right path
Sharps	Sharps mail-back kit
Dental amalgam & mercury	Amalgam recycling — we set it up
Pharmaceutical waste	Pharmaceutical waste kit
Controlled substances	Controlled / medication kit (DEA)

Waste stream	The right path
Biohazard / RMW	Biohazard mail-back kit
Hazardous & special	RCRA-hazardous kit + silver/lead recycling

Prefer pickup, or higher volume?

Mail-back is the fastest path for most dental offices. But if you run multiple locations, generate higher volume, or simply prefer scheduled pickup, we'll size a custom program for you — get a quote at easyrxcycle.com/get-a-quote or call 501-904-2929.

WHY DENTAL PRACTICES CHOOSE EASY RX CYCLE

- No contract, no minimums — buy as you need
- Flat-rate pricing — no fuel or hidden surcharges
- One vendor for every stream you generate
- DEA-registered, EPA- & OSHA-aligned destruction
- A Certificate of Destruction on every single order

Ready to simplify your dental waste?

Shop dental kits with prices, or get a custom quote for pickup and higher volume. No contract, cancel anytime.

501-904-2929 · sales@easyrxcycle.com · easyrxcycle.com/shop